

Cycling with Arthritis: A Low-Impact Way to Keep Moving

Cycling is one of the best exercises for arthritic joints. Learn how to set up your bike, choose the right type, and ride comfortably.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Cycling with Arthritis



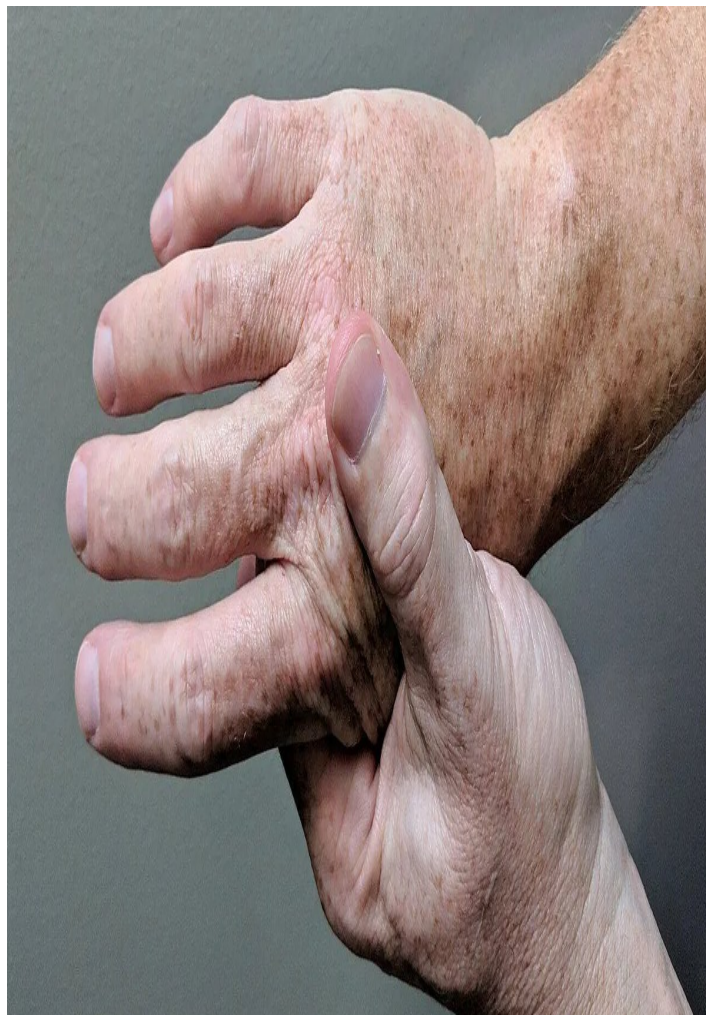
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Cycling is consistently recommended by rheumatologists and physiotherapists as one of the best exercises for arthritis. It's low-impact, builds leg strength, improves cardiovascular fitness, and can be adapted to almost any ability level.

Why Cycling Works for Arthritis

Minimal joint loading: Unlike walking or running, cycling is non-weight-bearing — your body weight is supported by the saddle. This makes it suitable for moderate to severe knee, hip, and ankle arthritis.

Controlled range of motion: The circular pedalling motion takes joints through a smooth, predictable range — lubricating cartilage with synovial fluid and reducing stiffness.



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Muscle strengthening: Pedalling primarily targets the quadriceps, hamstrings, glutes, and calves — the key muscle groups that support arthritic knees and hips.

****Cardiovascular fitness:**** A 2018 Cochrane review confirmed that aerobic exercise (including cycling) reduces pain and improves function in knee and hip OA.

Types of Cycling

****Stationary/exercise bike:**** Best for beginners or during flare-ups. No balance required, controlled environment, and you can stop instantly. Recumbent bikes (with back support) are excellent for hip and back arthritis.



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****E-bikes (electric-assist):**** The game-changer for arthritis cycling. E-bikes provide motor assistance when you need it — up hills, into headwinds, or when fatigue hits. They let you ride further with less joint stress. UK e-bike sales have surged, and prices now start from around £800.

****Standard road/hybrid cycling:**** For those with mild to moderate symptoms. Hybrid bikes with upright geometry are more comfortable than racing bikes.

****Adapted cycling:**** Tricycles, recumbent trikes, and hand cycles are available through Cycling UK's Cycling Without Age programme and many local Wheels for All centres.

Bike Setup for Arthritis

****Saddle height:**** When seated, your knee should have a slight bend (25–30°) at the bottom of the pedal stroke. Too low = excess knee compression. Too high = hip rocking.

****Handlebar height:**** Raise handlebars higher than the saddle to maintain an upright position — this reduces strain on wrists, shoulders, and lower back.

****Pedals:**** Platform pedals (not clipless) let you reposition your feet during the ride. Add toe cages if you want some security without the commitment of cleats.

****Grips:**** Ergonomic grips (like Ergon GP1) distribute pressure across the palm rather than concentrating it on the fingers — essential for hand arthritis.

****Gear ratios:**** Use low gears and spin at a higher cadence (70–90 RPM) rather than pushing hard in high gears. High resistance = more joint force.

Getting Started

****Week 1–2:**** 10 minutes on a stationary bike, low resistance, every other day ****Week 3–4:**** Increase to 15–20 minutes, gentle resistance ****Week 5–6:**** Try 20–30 minutes, or venture outdoors on flat routes ****Ongoing:**** Build to 30–45 minutes, 3–4 times per week

UK Resources

- ****Cycling UK:**** Offers inclusive cycling programmes and route suggestions
- ****Wheels for All:**** Centres across the UK providing adapted cycles and supported sessions
- ****British Cycling Breeze:**** Women-only social rides at a gentle pace
- ****Sustrans:**** National Cycle Network with traffic-free routes

Key Takeaway

Whether it's a stationary bike in your living room or an e-bike through the countryside, cycling lets you stay active, protect your joints, and enjoy the freedom of movement that arthritis tries to take away.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about cycling with arthritis: a low-impact way to keep moving?

Short answer: Cycling is ideal for arthritis as it's low-impact, supporting your body weight and reducing joint loading. The circular pedalling motion lubricates cartilage and strengthens leg muscles supporting knees and hips. Stationary, e-bikes, and adapted cycles offer options for all abilities, with correct bike setup, including saddle and handlebar height, crucial for comfort and joint protection.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk